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THE 1964 PRESIDENTIAL ELECTION, as historians and journalists have amply recorded, was a disaster for our party. Not only was Goldwater swamped under a Lyndon Johnson landslide, the party came out of the election bitterly divided because of a vicious primary battle between Goldwater and Nelson Rockefeller. A lot of liberal Republicans simply refused to support Goldwater against Johnson. The split was especially deep in California, where moderate and conservative factions of the party had already been feuding for years.

After the election, I went back to doing what I'd been doing before it—speaking on national issues and doing my job on "Death Valley Days." The following spring, Holmes Tuttle, a Los Angeles automobile dealer who had been one of the Republican contributors I'd met at the Coconut Grove dinner and who later bought the airtime for my speech for Goldwater, called me and asked if he and several friends might drop by our home in Pacific Palisades.

After I heard what they said, I almost laughed them out of the house. I can't remember my exact words, but I said, in effect: "You're out of your mind."

Tuttle and the other members of his group said they wanted me to run for governor in 1966, when Pat Brown, the liberal Democrat who had beat Nixon for reelection in 1962, was expected to run for a third term.

I'd never given a thought to running for office and I had no interest in it whatsoever. After doing as much research as I had on the operations of government, the last thing I wanted was to become a part of it. I just wanted to keep on making speeches about it.